



NEWSLETTER YO GT AN T RA GAM A



Jan -March 2015

From the Editor- in -Chief's desk:

By Swami Paranand Tirth

EDITOR- IN -CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH



ऐदस्मेवशयासनस्म दधत ो भध्मेराटप्रबाभ्
शौकर ोकोततभनुष्णगोरयवतशयस्मातन्वतसववत्रः

एषासौत्रनुयाहृददयुततरयवोष्णोशोसदाहःस्थता
तिन्द्यानःसहसा

नदैस्तिबयघोज्मोततभवम वोग्भम॥ १

Wisdom the greatest penance .
सवं ानप्रवेनैववृस्िनोसोतरयष्मतत

Thou shalt cross the ocean of sins just by resorting to the raft of wisdom . According to Laxmitantra a brahmin who is unable to undertake the vedic penance for various moral and other trepidation should seek resort to the tantras . Most of the repentances ordained in the vedas and their subservient canons are either so severe or impractical that a sinner has to choose between self mortification or self extinction besides the statutory punishment which if awarded by a righteous ruler saves the sinner from a posthumous hell. As the human kind became more and more deviant in a Vedic

sense a milder and more practical notion of repentance came to be defined in more contemporary consistent terms. In Gita a converted sinner has been applauded as a sage .He should be considered as a saint since he has



changed his deviant ways and is properly oriented .Agamas are one step ahead they attribute five powers to Parameshwara : Creation, sustenance, dissolution, relinquishing and redeeming. The fifth function called अनुग्रहvests all powers of deliverance from transgressions and the imparting of the supreme wisdom on Parashiva.

A vedic scholar must live in isolation in a hutment miles away from the civilization for twelve years ,for some nominal sins like drinking alcohol . There are many such sins which require a lifelong penance and the sinner is excluded from the clan forever.

So Laghu Acharya with his divine acumen and wisdom prays to the supreme mother of the universe who manifests in the form of the three mystic seed syllables to deliver him from all transgressions instantaneously. There was a couple of Tulsidas Ji regarding the phenomena of instantaneous deliverance from sins . Not just one particular sin but the

virtually perpetuated trail of transgressions.

As soon as a man confronts me he is delivered from all his sins which he may have accumulated through billions of lives.

सम्मुखोम ि व भभ िफही िन्भ कोदट
अघ नातशक तफही

An immediate eradication of not only the vices but also the vicious tendencies is what the Tantras aim at. The supreme mother manifests in the form of will, work and wisdom (ान इच्िा दिमा) if these three are in

a conducive proportion they lead to a righteous mind set. A disproportional configuration leads to a moral crash land. More desiresless knowledge unruly action and disaster .more knowledge less desire regulated action leads to completion. More action less desire, less knowledge is a sort of bonded slavery. More action less knowledge less desire can make a fanatic out of person. One cannot be expected to exercise his control over this triad individually or collectively so there is no other alternative except praying for their perfect balance.

ज्ञानजन्याभवेदिच्छाइच्छाजन्या दिया भवेत्

In the parlance of a perfect being knowledge leads to desire and desire leads to action . In a commoner's parlance experience leads to desire and desire leads to knowledge . To sync with the wave length of the perfect being one must have faith and devotion . There are six steps to subservience. A commitment of whatever is agreeable to the mother of the universe and refraining from whatever is disagreeable, accepting the divine mother as the sole resort ,total surrender, piety , and a firm belief that the holy mother is my succour. This six fold surrender is more popular among the votaries of qualified monism but in the context of the worship of the divine mother this has been mentioned as some adaptation in the second portion of the Brahmand puranam which is compendium of the adoration of Shrividyā worship.

Meditations on three mantras

ऐं(aim) करलं(kilm), स ौः (sauh)

Each mystic syllable is not just phonetic sound but has a great deal of wisdom encrypted in them. The first one which is I turn encrypted In this canto as the first syllable of the phrase ऐंद्रस्मेव.....

Bearing a hue as if that of a rainbow in the

middle of the fore head. This seed syllable which is further enunciated in the consequent verse has four portions each taken from the first syllable of the first mantra of each veda

.अ from the Rikveda,इ from the Yajurveda ,अ from the Sama and the nasal sound from the शै of the Atharva Veda .

The next seed syllable is yet another reservoir of spiritual energy the very process of its pronunciation orientates the current of psycho physiological energy to conduce to an accelerated pace of spiritual evolution. Without such boosts the natural pace of spiritual evolution is too slow and arbitrary. The guttural contraction while mentally pronouncing the syllable क्क diverts upwards

the otherwise dissipating energy. In the ancient Brahmi characters this syllable is written as a cross the later developed into Greek kappa and similar guttural syllable in other languages which has a deep mystic import. It has been named as the crossroad of transcendence which corresponds to the region of epiglottis in the physical body. According to the arcane etymology of such mystic encryptions the syllable or let us say half syllable क्क stands for the bliss and the next

semi syllable र्द denotes stability the fourth vowel with nasal accent is a notion of the absolute principle .hence the seed of Cupid as it is metaphorically named -pertains to the तनयतशम आनोद or the supreme spiritual bliss aspect of the absolute. The complete or ब्रूमा alone is blissful whatever besides this is transient ephemeral and conditioned.

There are two principle drives which determine almost all tendencies of sentient creature's libido drive and thematic impulse. In the glossary of eastern metaphysics these are called the impulses of नयमानोदप्राति and सवावनथवनवृत्त. These two drives function from

deep within our psyche and are rather instinctive and therefore beyond our control . These can be transcended only through the impetus of an authentic spiritual lineage. A preceptor helps you go beyond your lower nature which is perpetually subject to the never ending trail of nescience desire and compulsive actions. The tyranny of this trio can be transcended only through the munificence of a guru and the motivation of his uninterrupted spiritual lineage.

The third seed syllable is highly esoteric and arcane. The entire universal phenomena have been ontologically encrypted as pertaining to the three portions of the conglomeration of the thirty six elementary constituents of the objective phenomena. Two canons namely para pravesika and paratrishika have been attributed to exposition

this seed syllable which is known by many names like Para, Shar, Shakti, Tritya, so on and so forth

This has been enunciated as the third brahma in paratrishika

ततथ शोतमुतोबदे चतुदवशसभस्वतो

तूत मोब्रह्मसुश्रोष्ण हृदमो बैयवातभनः

O goddess with shapely girdle this arcane secret of bhairav comprises the last nasal ो

And the fourteenth vowel I.e औ .

Somtilak Soori propounds in his commentary that in Kaul practice the aspirata is substituted by nasalis .In yet another school of tantrik ism both aspirata and nasalis are used. Some explain this as per their pertinence to Hayagriva, Anandabhairav and Dakshinamurti sects of Tripursundari adoration.

.The termination of all sins including the sinful tendencies is a concomitant process .It is unrealistic to make a list of all your misdeeds of the past and repent for them one by one.

Nescience caused all those sins and wisdom undoes their effects

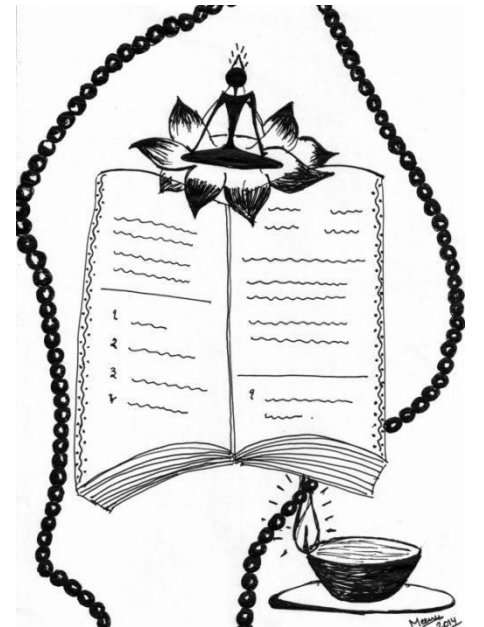
तदतधगभेअश्लेषशत्रवनाशौनूवावनयमोयघमो

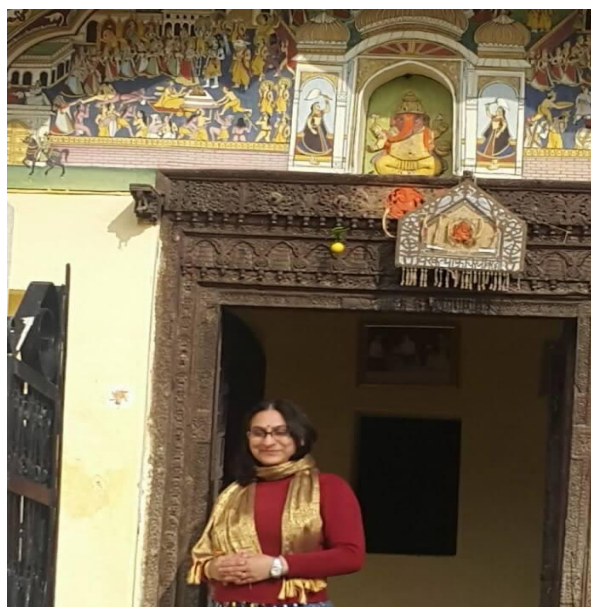
Realization of the self terminates all sins preceding or following the epiphany.

Swami Paranand Tirth

Founder President and CEO

YTA YogaTantra andAgama(Inc.)





Editorial

Often while discussing aesthetics concepts in class I witness an uneasy silence and sudden introspective behavior which lends a serious demeanor to usually playful and naughty faces. Somewhere in our 'will filled consciousness', to borrow a term from

Schopenhauer we are so caught up with our mundane lives and desires that there is a total disconnect from the real self. Such discussions often take us away from our concocted comfort zones and bring us face to face with uneasy questions pertaining to existence and purpose of life. Many of us feel threatened and evade such uncomfortable situation by getting more and more enmeshed in the surrounding noise. But a time comes when one no longer can neglect the inner voices and its questionings. It is then that the seeker starts his/her journey usually by delving in philosophy where they hope to find answers to ever troubling questions. It is this unending quest which once started catches you by hand and leads you from various labyrinths opening multiple vistas and introduces you to a mysterious world of spiritual awakening.

It is this door that we hope to knock at and enter with the blessings of our guru and mentor Swami Parannad Tirth, a door which ultimately opens to our own hearts. With myriad contributions from scholars and seekers we at YTA try to assimilate various thought processes and put them forth for the benefit of our readers. We embark on our journey with an enlightening editorial by Swami Paranand Tirthji explaining the importance of sutras and esoteric power of verses from Panchastavi and its power to lead to ultimate realization of self. In the Perspective

section we again have two articles, first by Swami Paranand Tirth on the significance of the postures and various mudras in dance of Shiva and the semiotic meaning of the beats of his damaru (rattle drum) and the birth of the spoken and written language visualized as a devi 'Vak'. The second article by Dr. G.L. Kaw is a quest in the nature of Puranic stories and pleads the need to penetrate their apparent superficial form and discern the deep embedded message inside. As Vyasa puts it: to reach the core substance of Puranic events, we need a very fine and trained intellect, vision and comprehension. Puranic stories do not belong to a particular era or age, but span all the three time periods and stretch to all the three Lokas or worlds.

To understand the concept of mysticism in Sufi order we have Rashneek Kher writing on the philosophical concepts of 'Fana' and 'Baqa' with appropriately quoted verses to explain his point. Sufis stress the need for moral transmutation of the inner self which they say is possible by purging the lower self of its attributes like ignorance and pride etc. Next we have an insightful article on the concept of Dana (Charity) in Buddhism and its significance by Niraj Kumar. Connecting the idea with the teachings of *madhyam marga* by Gautama Buddha, he stresses upon the importance of *dana* by suggesting that if *dana* is a *Parmita* as well as *yagya*, the great donors should be conferred such respect through a continuous tradition. This will boost the culture of philanthropy in the emerging economies like India where the generosity index is very poor.

We also have some poems dedicated to Mother Goddess by Nita Rubbio who seems to have been inspired by the concept of feminine divine. The titles like 'Terrible Beauty' and 'Feeding the Guardian' points at the mysticism dealt with. In the end we have an article on Sri Sankuka's views on *rasa sutra* by

Geetika Kaw Kher. All the Indian aesthetes who have commented on the *Rasa-Sutra* of Bharata, essentially from Kashmir, have been great thinkers and philosophers in their own right. The fact that they could derive so much out of a simple appearing *sutra* and for generations comment on it talks of their excellent scholarship, power to articulate and condense the essence of the written word.

Geetika Kaw Kher

(Dr. Geetika Kaw Kher is Asst. Professor at Amity School of Fine Arts (ASFA) and teaches History of Art, Aesthetics and Art Criticism)

hurls the awareness in a pure objective realm Shiva the universal self as pure unalloyed subjective consciousness tramples him under his feet



WISDOM FROM SHIVA'S RATTLE DRUM

Swami Paranand Tirth

2.

THE COSMIC DANCE

नटयायिाि

नृतावसाने ो ननाद ढकको नवनञ्चवायभ ् ।
उद्धृतुवकाभ् सनकाददतसद्धानेतदिभशे तशवसूत्रिरभ ् ॥१॥

And after his cosmic dance Shiva played his damru fourteen times to redeem the four sons of Brahma the creator ,thus producing fourteen aphorisms on which the entire grammar of Panini is caricatured .

Owing to the dynamic course of the universal phenomena with a stable and eternal substratum as its base, the threshold of perpetual motion and absolute rest is the zone of Shivas dance . The dancing as such is relatively perpetual and the dancing floor is the stationary substratum. Just a change in the perspective ends the eternal dance. As the awareness heads the substratum there is eternity, tranquility and stability .from a conventional stand point there is perpetual, dynamism, motion and a cyclic mode of displacement. Dance is all about cyclic movement. Steps, rhythm, beats and postures or mudras are repeated and change systematically. In the tradition of Indian dramaturgy a lady dance is called lasyam and gents dance is called tandavam. The dancer moves his hand above the head and raises his other leg ,knee above the thigh. Then the posture is repeated with other arm and leg

.without missing a step and keeping his pace with rhythm and beat . This dance is performed on the body of a demon. Just big enough to balance the lords sole . This demon called apasmar literally meaning epilepsy but can be construed to mean -" the oblivion of the metaphysical truth " generates a faulty and aberrant world view from his own erroneous imagery .Shiva the universal preceptor dances to impede his erroneous perspective and then to infuse his own taint less view point. The demon



with agile dexterity and adroitness after the demon is totally subjugated his cosmic dance stops and as a triumphant expression of mind over matter he plays his rattle drum fourteen times. His first acolytes were the four offsprings of Brahma the creator .They defied their fathers command to procreate and chose to seek absorption in their spiritual magnanimity ,naturally Shiva the master of the spiritual truth became their preceptor.

During the ancient days Brahmins never married one prominent Upanishads goes on to say - They mused of what avail is progeny to us since our essential nature is our ultimate objective.

Dynamism in a divine parlance is the synchrony of movements rhythm and beats .but this is not a physical and gross movement as in the conventional dance and dramaturgy but esoteric and subtle . This dance of Shiva is related to the element of air .which as per the ancient syllogism pertains to the seven attributes viz . Motion, whirling, running, contraction, expansion, throwing up and down. These bear a striking semblance to the process of dancing.

The dance of annihilation has been aesthetically depicted by Puspdanta a great Shiva devotee:
*As thou danceth to save the universe from
Untimely annihilation.*

By the stamping of you mighty feet the earth is pulverised,
By the whirling of your four arms all planets and constellation are tumultuous
As thy unfastened dread locks thrash against the horizon the heavens move
deviant indeed are the ways of the display of thy grandeur . (*Shiv Mahimastutih*)

In some of the Shiva's relics we have a mudra called *harini*. The gesture of a doe Or impala displayed by touching the tips of the middle and ring

fingers with tip of the thumb and by extending the ring and little finger. This gives it the semblance of a leaping impala .this mudra signifies control over the element of air which as it were also interlaces the universal phenomena as the cosmic *prana* -the vital force. The aerial process of Shiva's dance stops at the threshold of air and ether or the switching of the awareness from touch to sound . Reversing the process of divergence as given the sutra *हयवर्ट* leads to the origin of creation

which in this context is ether. There are five gradations of the element of ether in the tantric canons, in an order of subtlety. Gross subtle subtler and causal the fifth being the ether of consciousness Kalidasa has named this as *chidgaganam*. As the realm of dynamism leads to that of quietude of placidity the dance of shiva culminates into the word of Shiva or the materialization of these fourteen mystic aphorism Natananandnath a mystic scholar while commenting on the *Kamakala vilas* of punyanand pro pounds the origin of conceived word or *Pashyanti* in the beats of percussionist . Especially those mounted with leather etc. this girl origin of word is somewhat like the divine theory of origin of word in the linguistics. The word from Shivas rattle drum is not the type one can listen and comprehend directly .On the other hand as the tradition goes the wisdom of omniscient Shiva has to be decoded on order to be rendered cognizable to humankind that is through a mediation of adepts in the lore of expression or grammar. Somanand the author of *Shivdristi* has opined with the theory that nescience unites with *Vak* in the *Pashyanti* stage when owing to its divergent disposition which in turn is definable as the deviation between the word and meaning -the *Pashyanti* or collective intellect is on the verge of being conditioned into the *Madhyama* or individual reasoning. The induction of nescience or *ajnana*, as it were accounts for the above mentioned conditioning .All revelations pertain to the domain of *pashyanti vak* which becomes cognizable and expressible in the grosser and grossest manifestations in the consequent orders of divergence named *Madhyama*, *Vaikhari*.

Para vak has no or nominal divergence so there is no trace of revelation ability. Owing to its pure subjective disposition it is rather the substratum of revelation-ability. The state of perfect subjective awareness can only be induced mystically .The self evident gnosis is in fact the substratum form for all stages of word and meaning reciprocations. It does have a mode of propagation of the subjective awareness through a dichotomy of *Devi* and *Dev*. The ingenious exposition of *paratrishika* by Maheshwara Abhinavagupta has been interpreted as a quasi soliloquy. This is monologue and dialogue simultaneously since the distinction between Shiva and Shakti does not really exist neither actually nor intellectually. The import of the word *Devi* is nothing else but *Para Vak*. And since there is no objectivity in this mode of pure transcendence the expression *देवउवाच* is often seen as the voice of the transcendental authority.

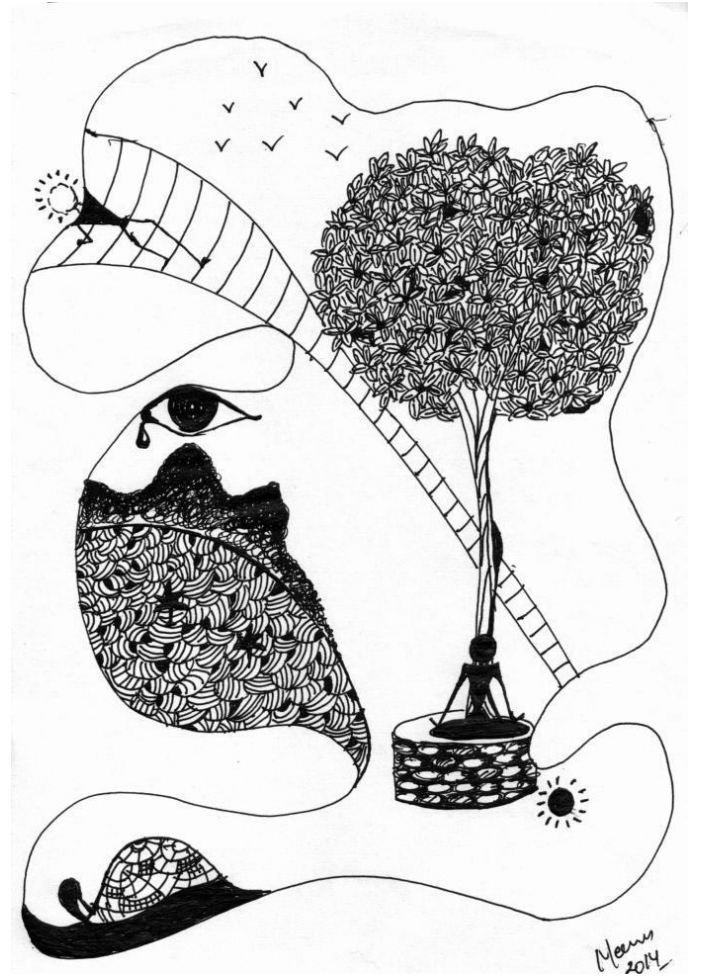
From Abhinavagupta Gupta viewpoint has a great mystic import. This soliloquy in the *Para* stage of divergence manifests as the dawning of the spiritual insight in the consequent *Pashyanti* stage. This is the threshold of individual cognition and the collective or cosmic intelligence

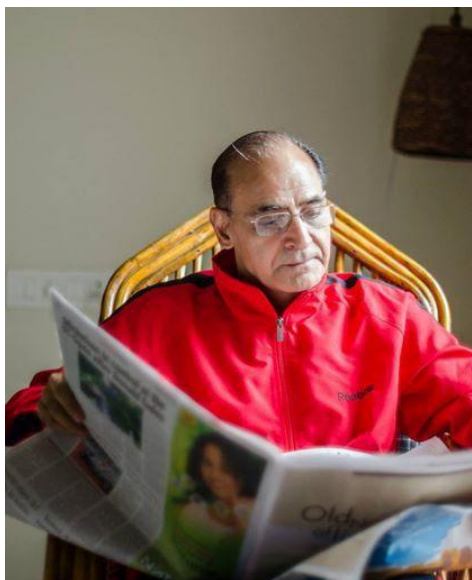
.Revelations bridge the gap .The imparting of intuitive insight as well as the discursive knowledge happens on the borderline of *Pashyanti* and *Madhyama* therefore there is no room for verbal interaction since the glossary of any description is yet to manifest . As one legend among the Sanskrit purists of the yore goes among the five recipients of the Maheshwar Sutras only *Nandikeshwara* could assimilate the metaphysical import the rest could comprehend this merely in grammatical context.

Like the photons of light these aphoristic compilations and for that matter all the syllabic manifestation of the universal phenomena is self evident and requires no other testimony of evidence for the vindication

of their existence. In the process of a divergent reciprocation of the phenomena the subjective self evidence is concealed and hence the term *matrikas* or the discreet quanta of the conveyance of knowledge (the suffix *कन* in the root *भातृ* signifies latency or discreet disposition).One school of the Vedic purists claim that the Vedic dictum is *तनयने यवः* or the independently resonate eternal word. This notion is also commonplace in various Semitic cults but the evolution of the universal phenomena intellectual as well actual is not as sophisticatedly defined as among the ancient Sanskrit grammarians. A sutra or a thread is spun from a seemingly dos arranged but immense amount of the knowledge of cotton. The cotton that would fill an entire room could easily be carried in your pocket if spun into a reel. During the ancient days a novice was supposed to mug up all aphorisms and then learn their commentaries and expositions. The classical definition of a sutra requires it to be as follow: a) alphabetically minimum; b) without ambiguity or vagueness; c) essentially meaningful; d) universality; d) easy to pronounce without singing and; e) unalloyed. Even from a corporeal viewpoint these sutras are flawless and thus authentic.

(To be continued.)





Puranas: Myths, mysteries and meanings

Dr G.L. Kaw

Do Puranic stories have any relevance in modern times? What is their value or importance? Archeologists and research scholars may find in them a goldmine of information, but do these Puranas and their stories apart from information convey any purposeful meaning for the present day common man?

The answers to this important query are not easy and straightforward. To reach the essence of these stories and myths, one has to penetrate their superficial coverings and realize the deep set hidden nectar which in essence is nothing but the gist of the Vedic Richas and Upnishadic Mantras. Focusing on the importance of Puranic literature Maharshi Ved Vyasa, considered to be the compiler of the main Puranas says:

Yo vidyat caturo vedaan saangopnishado dvijah,

Puranam cet na vidyat na sa syat suvichakshanah.

i.e. — One who knows Vedas as well as Upanishads, but is ignorant of Puranas, he cannot be considered as a good scholar|| .

To a casual reader, Puranic stories sound like the extreme examples of hyperbole and fancy flights of imagination mainly due to the limitations of our own sense organs, our understanding and level of comprehension. As Vyasa puts it: to reach the core substance of Puranic events, we need a very fine and trained intellect, vision and comprehension. Puranic stories do not belong to a particular era or age, but span all the three time periods and stretch to all the three Lokas or

- A) According to Divine point of view- **Adhidivik** - the description is : Pura api navam iti bhati.

Whatever is ancient, seems and feels new or recent is Purana. Since Puranas concern subtle worlds, desires and soul; which are eternal subjects they are relevant to past as much as to present. This calls for a totally different understanding of time than the usual linear notion accepted in history.



worlds. The very meaning of the Purana can be understood at three levels, namely

- A) Material—(Aadhibhoutik); B) Divine – (Aadhidhaivik); and C) Spiritual ((Aadhyatmik.)

Material- **Adhibhautik**

This view point may seem deceptively very simple.

— Pura bhavam iti Puranam||

i.e. whatever has taken place in the distant past is described in Puranas. Thus we see events and stories about creation of the universe, history of various ages as well as destruction thereof. But this process of creation, sustenance and destruction has not taken place at a particular point of time in distant past only. These eternal processes are going on even at the present instant also. Puranas bring this very fact to our notice. That is why Puranas are described as :

—Pura neeyate iti Puranam”

i.e. whatever is very near, related and contained around us, Puranas bring it to our attention. Moreover, Puranas do not concern only the past and present but future as well. In fact, Puranas help us to see the junction of past and future. Another unique quality of these events and stories is that these are equally relevant to universe as well as to an individual- termed as Brahmand and Pind in Shastras.

- B) The Spiritual point of view- **Adhyatmik**— states

Pura na vidyate iti:

i.e. whatever does not become old or ancient is the God, the Brahman or Puranapurush, who is eternal, immutable and omnipresent. And Puranas describe and ascribe to this entity only.

The Puranic stories traverse from material to spiritual world seamlessly. If one understands this literature in its real perspective, then it is never old, ancient or irrelevant. Since these stories relate to all the time spans and also to universe as well as individual, many scholars describe Puranas as not pre-historical but para-historical. Puranas do not always comment on human-centric subjects but there is mention of a vast universe, infinite horizons riding on a megawheel of time. When a man of stable intellect comprehends the reality, when tiniest and monumental; momentary and eternal; living and non-living lose their identity in a singular phenomenon, then the proverbial tenth door (**dasham dwaar**) opens for his liberation.

There are many Puranas. Main or Maha-puranas are eighteen in number but there are many others called Up-puranas. Infact the word Puran has been misused and maligned in recent centuries by a battery of not always well-meaning writers, by affixing the word Puran to the title of their works. This has at least caused the confusion among the masses if nothing else. The ten main attributes and objectives of a Mahapurana are elucidated in Brahmvaivart Puran as follows:

- i) Sarg - Creation of universe.
- ii) Vi-sarg— Special creation of and by Brahma.
- iii) Vriti/Sthiti— Sustenance and behavior.
- iv) Raksha/ Palan— Nurturing along with security.
- v) Antaram/ Avadhi--- Pause
- vi) Vaarta Manunam--- Geneology of Manu and his decedents.
- vii) Vanshayanum Charitam- Characteristics of great souls.
- viii) Nyayniti— Organization.
- ix) Hetu— Actual objectives and reasons of creation.
- x) Apashrya— Absolute independence/ moksha.

Actually, whatever is relevant to human life is described, discussed and dissected in Puranas in a very gross and evident form, albeit, in their peculiar sign language (*Sanketic Bhasha*). In fact subtle and symbolic specks of light in Vedic and Upanishadic Mantras have been injected with life force, even presented in a gross body and made to ambulate and vibrate. Unfortunately, now-a-days we cannot decipher the basic essence of these stories as we have lost the master key for the same. We have plenty of Puranic story-tellers (Varta-kaars/ kathaakaars), but how many of them can make us comprehend the embedded meaning. There are millions of listeners also, but how many care to reach the essence of these stories?

There is a famous story in Bhagwat Purana:

Gokarna was telling the story and the fruits of listening to the same in front of a large audience. Only one listener, namely Dhundhukari, who happened to be in a ghost form (*Pret-Yoni*) got the fruit of liberation/moksha and ascended to heavens in a plane (*Viman*), especially sent for him. Gokarna was surprised and asked from Vishnu's associates for the explanation. The answer he got is simple but sweet:

Shravanasya vibheden phalabhedoatra sansthitah,
Shravanam tu kritam sarvaye na tatha mannanam kritam.
Phalbhedo tatah jato bhajnaat api Maanad.

i.e. This is due to the difference in listening. Even after listening carefully if there is not complete comprehension, internalization and

constant repetition (Mannan) in your heart, the fruits will be different. Now the question arises, what is the right type of listening? Apparently when there is minimum noise and disturbance in our surroundings, we listen clearly. But minimizing external noise and disturbance is not enough. To listen one-pointedly we must have controlled the noise and disturbance of our mind also. Then only the desired fruit shall be realized. One who succeeds in these two stages of listening and Mannan the third and ultimate stage is entering (*Previshtum*) the essence of the reality. In Gita (11.54) Lord Krishna describes these three stages as understanding, seeing and entering of the substance, (*Gnatum, Drshtum, and Prveshtum*). Similarly, in *Bhagwat Purana* (12.11) the Supreme Reality or universal truth (*Vishvatma*) is described in very peculiar Puranic style. The ornaments, arms and the conveyance of the Deity (*Vishnu Murti*) is expressed and explained in detail, but in a covert manner. The way of worship and meditation on this deity is explained in the 17th shloka of the same chapter as under;

Mandalam devyajnam deeksha sanskaar

atmanah, Paricharya bhagwat atmano duritkhshya.

i.e. this whole universe is the place for worship of the God; Mantra-Diksha or the guidance from the Guru causes the purification of the mind; and to abdicate the bad desires is the service to God. Thus, living and practicing in this universe (*Brahmand*) to overcome the limitations of the individual (*Pind*), is the worship of the Universal Atman or Parmatman.

Thus it is clear that Purana-Kathas are not meant for cursory reading and light entertainment in our leisure time, but we must strive to understand and comprehend their language and essence. One is free to adopt any of the means of Bhakti (Devotion), Jnana (Knowledge) or Karma (Action) to enter this apparently dense forest of Puranas and reach the ultimate Goal.

(**Dr G.L Kaw** is a medical practitioner based in Gandhinagar Gujarat with an avid interest in history, philosophy classical Sanskrit and Persian literature)



Fana and Baqa

Rashneek Kher

The road from Dwarka to Somnath was terrible in patches. Abida Parveen was giving us company. His Holiness was in contemplation. I asked Swamiji, What is Baqa? He turned around and said that what carries on even after annihilation. He went back into contemplation. Abida kept singing;

Kahin Mumkin hua, kahin wajib

Kahin Fani kahin Baka Dekha

He was a possibility at times, At times Imperative

Ephemeral at times, At times Eternal

(Hazrat Shah Niyaz)

I often wondered, how could something live on even after it is annihilated. Isn't annihilation an end in itself? What thus could live after getting completely annihilated?

Anyone who has read or heard the Sufis would have often come across the lexicon of *Fana* and *Baqa*. Before we come to understand these two terms we must first deal with the concept of —mortification of the nafs||. *Nafs* itself is a recurring theme in Sufi writings. Every human being has a lower or appetitive soul- an evil self so to say. This evil self, the seat of passion and lust is called *Nafs*.

There is a concept of *Zinday Marun* in Kashmiri folklore. Generations of Kashmiri poets have dwelled upon this but none better than this verse explains the concept by Shams Faqir Kashmiri

Zinde Panay Gache Marunay

Rinde Sar ho Sapde Kunuh

Die you should when Alive

Bereft thus would you be of any duality

Nafs broadly to be understood as flesh with its associates the world and the devil, is the greatest obstacle to the attainment of union with God. The Prophet of Islam, Muhammad said ;

Thy worst enemy is thy Nafs which is between thy two sides.

The *Nafs* of Mansur Bin Hallaj was seen running behind him in the shape of a dog: some say in the shape of a snake or a mouse.

The Sufis understand that it is not entirely possible to kill the *Nafs*. However they stress the need for moral transmutation of the inner self which they say is possible by purging the lower self of its attributes like ignorance and pride etc.

When asked, who is a Muslim, the great mystic Nund Rishi says

*Krud, lubh, muh, mad, ahankar travi
Suy dapize musalman*

He who purges the Self of

Anger, Profiteering, Possessiveness, Ego & Pride* is a Muslim.

Sufis eternally strive to purge their heart of the above mentioned* characteristics. The one who reaches the stage of —Dying to Self|| reaches a stage of —living in God||. He who has eradicated self will reach the stage where his trust in God (*tawwakul*) is absolute. He has no volition of his own, is as passive as dead. Self surrender becomes self devotion. There is though an active method too which is often referred as to *Dhikr* or recollection or simply —thinking of||. Recollection can be aided in many ways. Among many Sufis music, singing and dancing are common methods of inducing trance. In this state there is a cessation of the conscious thought.

This Kaafi of Bulleh Shah represents this method of *Dhikr*,



Tere Ishq Nachaya Kar ke thaya thaya

Chaete Aave vay tabeeba nahee Ta main mar gayan

In your love, I dance in ecstasy

Oh my healer, come lest I die

Thus when the heart is purged of sin & evil thoughts, the light of intuitive certainty (yaqeen) strikes it and makes it a shining mirror. It is in this mirror that the Gnostic sees his *Mashooq* (the lover). A devil cannot enter this heart without being seen or observed. This is the state of Fana or complete annihilation of self, or merging of self into a greater self.

Ahmed Dar, the Kashmiri mystic poet says

Vichun Mashooq Pannaney Aayeenay

(See the lover in your own mirror)

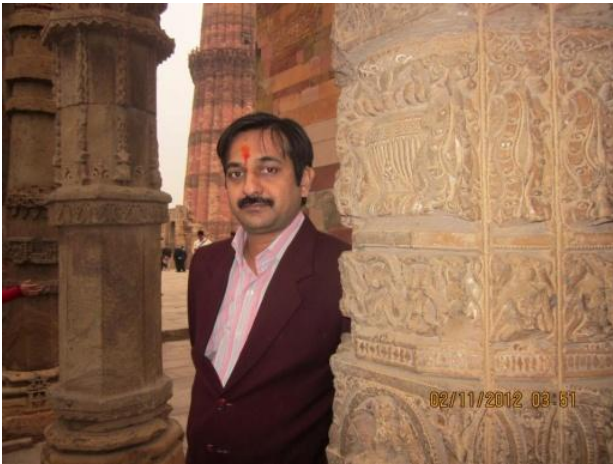
The State when even consciousness of having attained the state of *Fana* disappears, is called *Fana-al Fana*. This is the state of passing away of *passing away* and forms a prelude to continual abidance of the state of *Fana* which is called *Baqa*.

A man once comes to Bayazid's cell and asks, Is Bayazid here? He answers, is anyone here but God? The unitive state is the culmination of the process by which the soul is gradually free from all that is not, God. He who self lives in God, the consummation of his death marks the attainment of *Baqa*, the continuance of his real existence.

(**Rashneek Kher** is a Kashmiri poet and a literary critic living in exile in Faridabad)



Swami Paranand Tirth inaugurated the dialogue on —Rishi Parampara|| at Hindi Bhawan, New Delhi on 9th December, 2014. The programme was organized by Sri Ramanuja Mission Trust, Chennai.



Niraj Kumar

Buddha taught in *Kutadanta Sutta* how *dana* (दान) is a *mahayagya*(महाम). But, how can one donate wealth, if one does not earn wealth? Prosperity is necessary for earning merit and fuelling spiritual urge in the community. That is the Middle Path hidden in his teachings.

After Buddha's mahaparinirvana, no representation of Buddha was made for 4-5 centuries. The Stupa or footprints or empty throne were the symbol of Buddha. These were merely the indicators (*linga*). Stupa construction became popular in North India, particularly after Ashoka's conversion. Many of the Buddhist texts still describe how 84000 stupas were constructed by Ashoka some as far as Nangchen in China.

In the stupa, Buddha's relics were preserved and worshipped. Buddha would have forbidden his followers from worshipping his relics. Many sects emerged and there were seemingly contradiction between stories narrated by different sects. The criticism also gets shriller once the decadence grows in a sect. It was at this moment that the *Milindapanha* (~2nd century B.C.) became popular. Through, the dialogue of Nagasena and the Greek King Menander, the work tries to not only explain the layman's queries concerning various contradictions, but also divinizes Buddha. In the *Milindapanha*, it was stated that Buddha forbade only monks to worship relics and allowed laypersons to do so. In the text, the concept of sapta-ratna (सि यत्न) was developed with multiple interpretations. While on the one hand, Sapta-ratnas were seen as the seven moral virtues, in many parts of the work, it had literal meaning.

In the first century when Mahayana sect was formally established, Ashvaghosha composed *Buddhacharita* and divinized Buddha with miraculous powers. *Mahavastu* (Great event) developed the concept of eternal Buddha who is not under control of cycle of karma but of his own free will. Buddha could drink or eat as he wished and stay in world following ordinary customs and remain unaffected by the karma-cycle. *Mahavastu* further developed the idea that enlightenment was such an unachievable state that only a Buddha could know what it is. The enlightenment can no longer be attained by one's effort. Only a Buddha can lead to enlightenment by sharing his merit. By the second century, when the Lotus Sutra (*Saddharmapundarika*) was composed, complete theory of Bodhisattvas was established. As a layperson could not have approached Buddha through understanding, the only way left was through worship, prayer and devotion.

The concept of saptaratna lost its metaphoric meaning. To worship Buddha, stone casket of Buddha's relics began to be decorated with sapta-ratnas. The first Buddha statue can be traced to 1-2nd century A.D. in Bactria and Mathura. These were heavily decorated with jewellery. Subsequently, there was veritable market for manufacturing statues of different Dhyan-Buddhas and retinue gods and goddesses.

Mahavastu lists these sapta-ratnas as gold (स्वणव), silver (रुप्य), lapis lazuli (वैदमवू), crystal (स्पदटक), pearl (भुक्ता), red coral (रोदहततका), and agate भूयस्यगत्वा. The Lotus sutra went on to declare that one can reach nirvana through a symbolic bullock cart made of seven jewels. Buddha-kshetra was stated to be decorated with the lapis-lazuli. Lapis-lazuli became the most sought out gem by the Mahayana Buddhists.

If reaching nirvana is analogous to an upward journey, the concept of stations (*bhumi*) was developed. These *bhumis* (standard number is ten) are decorated with different kinds of gems. The Bodhisattva Amitabha, who is the Bodhisattva of compassion, is said to have created a *Sukhavativyuha*, the land of bliss (*sukha*) as a way station for those who are travelling over the path of nirvana. The *Sukhavativyuha* is said to have even trees that have sapta-ratna fruits. *Amitayur-Dhyan-Sutra* (meditation on Buddha), a text translated into Chinese in 424 A.D., describes the result of meditating under such trees made of sapta-ratna in the Sukhavati. Even in *Vajra-chhedik* (Diamond Cutter), translated into Chinese by Kumarajiva (384-417 A.D.), the merits of worshipping Buddha with sapta-ratna is described.

Thus, after divinization of Buddha and worship as the alternate route towards Nirvana, there was virtual revolution in the statue-making. This spurred the trade of goods and gems for the use in worship of Buddha. The Silk Route trade prospered. Asian countries prospered. Thus,

religious activity fundamentally changed the geoscape of Eurasia. Spread of religion, commerce and prosperity complemented each other's trajectory.

But, earning wealth to earn merit seems paradoxical. *How should one earn wealth?* There is the story of Bindumati in the *Dhanea-janisutta* of *Majjhimnikaya* in *Suttapitak*. The story is also narrated in the *Milindapanha*. Once upon a time, King Ashoka asked his courtiers that could anyone run the river Ganga backwards. There was a prostitute, Bindumati. She shocked Ashoka by achieving the feat. When Ashoka wanted to know how she was able to do this miracle, it was learnt that she attained merit by treating all customers equally. She had achieved the equanimity of mind by conducting herself indifferent towards the work she was performing. She was neither attached to the customers who offered her gold coins, nor was she abhorrent towards customers who were of low caste or offered her nothing of significant material value.

Thus, Buddhism does not discourage individuals from earning of wealth if one maintains the attitude of indifference towards the work and is not attached to the wealth. This attitude is termed as *upeksha* (उपेक्षा). If we

do not strive for prosperity, there will be scarcity of resources that might be the fertile ground for jealousy and hatred. In abundance, there is less degree of conflict-probability, in scarcity, it is more likely.

Early Mahayana summarized our conduct for attaining liberation while adjusting to material reality and succinctly under a short term: *Chaurbrahmaviharini* (चतुर्ब्रह्मचर्यहारयण). What are these four Brahmas?

Amicability (*meti*, मैत्र), compassion (*karuna*, करुणा), *mudita* (happiness, भुददता) and indifference (*upeksha*, उपेक्षा). There will be amicability in society only when the society will be prosperous. One cannot be compassionate if one does not possess. Only those who have attained something can share with the less privileged. Happiness also cannot be savoured if there is no healthy mind. Healthy mind requires healthy body. Healthy body requires prosperity in society.

A grim-looking saint or a philosopher can hardly share wisdom. The nature of wisdom is such that those who attain are buoyant with happiness and laughter. In Buddhism, much emphasis has been laid on laughter. In the *Lotus Sutra*, we find several mention of Bodhisattva *Gadgadasvara* (गदगदास्वय). In the earliest Tantras like *Guhyasamaj Tantra*, we have various construction of mantras with the phonemes _ha ha. he he|| (हा हा हे हे). In the *Chakrasanvara Tantra*, we find the culmination of such constructions into the laughter mantra (*Hasya mantra*) – हा हा हेहेहो हो हुँहूँ, इतत देववभौत्रेनत्रनअष्टत्रवधाउ हास! When the *Kalachakra tantra* emerged during the 10-11th century as synthesis of Indic sects, the most frequent mantra found in the work is again associated with laughter that symbolizes expression of happiness-

हा हा हा हो बगवान्

Similarly, we find the queer stories of 84 Mahasiddhas. We have the bizarre stories of Kuenlen Drukpa, the patron saint of Bhutan whose strange stories of sexual encounter make the most hilarious adult stories. All the Mahasiddhas including Tilopa and Naropa are depicted with a pot-belly. The pot-belly signifies abundance of food and healthy body. Statue of Hotei, the fat laughing Buddha is now a global traded commodity. Laughter and happiness can be relished only in abundance and through healthy body and healthy mind.

We have seen how the attitude of indifference while even earning wealth is equivalent to practicing Bodhichitta. *Upeksha* is a comprehensive attitude to overcome anger, greed and fear.

These four Brahmas (*maitri, karuna, mudita, upeksha*) are of the nature of Brahma as these always spread. Brahma (ब्रह्मा) is that which expands (brih: बृह्, to spread). Thus, the practice of these four virtues has contagion effect over society. It is self-evident how the friendship, compassion, laughter have tonic effect over the group. *Upeksha* does produce similar stimulating effect in group dynamics. The collective practice of these four virtues can stimulate the effort to establish prosperity in society and only a prosperous community can practise generosity to sustain the organized religion.

Tilopa, the Guru of Naropa and a Mahasiddhas composed the teachings of Mahamudra in his *Ganga Mahamudra* . He describes how flow of life is analogous to the flow of the river Ganga. There are three stages in the river. When it originates from waterfall, there is turbulence, thence it goes slower in expanse and in the delta stage, and the river joins the vast calm ocean. Similarly, the materialism appears like *turbulence* when one starts the practice to realize truth, thence one starts savouring the *opulence* of the spiritual quest. But, the next stage ought to be that of *confluence* where both – materialism and spirituality joins and fuses. This realization has been bracketed as the Mahamudra (महामुद्रा) among the Himalayan Buddhism practicing Naropa's Six Yogas. If the materialism is the *bimba* (बिम्बा), spirituality should be seen as the *pratibimba* (प्रतिबिम्बा), its reflection. But, the next stage ought to be shedding off the separation between two- annihilation of both-the thing and its reflection. This *bimba-nishpatti* (बिम्बा-निष्पत्ति) is the stage of

Mahamudra. It is not like dialectical operation where there is synthesis at the higher stage. Mahamudra entails shedding off both –the thing and its opposite, being and non-being. Mahamudra tradition of Buddhism emphasizes the natural state of thing. Term *Mahamudra* itself consists of two terms-maha(Great) and Mudra(seal). Mudra is derived from the root *Mudita*, the happiness. Thus, Mudra is that which provides happiness. The term is now also used in Indian subcontinent signifying money, and naturally so, since money always provides happiness to the acquirer. There are three ways to realize original, pure joy- through wisdom, through action and the self-arising. The first is categorized as Jnanamudra (ज्ञानमुद्रा), the second as Karmamudra (कर्ममुद्रा), and the supreme path is the Mahamudra (महामुद्रा). It is self-arising and not dependent on anything external or internal. It is the state of natural spontaneous joy. In such state of *being natural*, there is no more boundary between profane or sacred; materialism and spirituality. Everything that is, is pure and void. There is joy of indivisibility just like a clear sky. Such Masters disappear after their death into clear sky like a splash of rainbow. If the generous wealthy individuals help build giant stupas laden with seven jewels (*sapta-ratna*), these spiritual giants become memorial of their lineages through their attainment of rainbow Bodies (rainbow is also known as *sapta-rangi*). None is superior or inferior to the other. Himalayan Buddhists practice the concept of reincarnation for the higher lamas. These Tulkus and Rinpoches are wonder-kids in their areas. They are worshipped as avatar (अवतार) from their childhood. Avatar is one who descends (ava) to help other cross over (tra त्र) this worldly affairs. But, another meaning of the root *ava* (अव) is _to be glad_ , —to help others|| .¹ Avatar are those who are glad to

help others cross over their sorrows. I would like to suggest that the generous wealthy individuals who have donated immensely to help others, too, should be identified as avatar. If *dana* is a *Parmita* as well as *yagya*, the great donors should be conferred such respect through a continuous tradition. This will boost the culture of philanthropy in the emerging economies like India where the generosity index is very poor. We can have avatar of Apple Founder Steve Jobs. Similarly, we can have avatar of Warren Buffet or Bill Gates in future. **Coming together of a Gyalwang Rinpoche and a Gates Rinpoche will be the ultimate Buddhist Middle Path that the world civilization needs urgently.**

(**Acknowledgement:** The author is indebted to Xinri Liu for the excellent exploration of spread of Buddhism and prosperity across the Silk Road in the masterly work, *Silk and Religion: An Exploration of Material Life and the Thought of People*, AD 600-1200, OUP, 1997)

(**Niraj Kumar** is associated with Society for Asian Integration. He is a disciple of Swami Ranganathanandaji Maharaj of Ramakrishna Mission.)

1. अव- Ava-avitum, to be glad, to enjoy one's self, to satisfy one's self with (with loc.) ; to do good to anyone ; to satisfy, to fill ; to like, wish, desire, love ; to be pleased with, to bestow great care upon; to avour, promote, animate; to help, guard, defend, protect. See Monnier –Williams, Monier. [A Sanskrit-English Dictionary: Etymologically and Philologically Arranged with Special Reference to Cognate Indo-European languages](#), revised by E. Leumann, C. Cappeller, et al. 1899, [Clarendon Press, Oxford](#), p.87.





Mother Calling!-Poems by Nita Rubio

Tra La La La La

Yesterday I touched Space.
 Or did it touch me?
 I know that my fear touched me.
 My awe.
 I understand now, those that retreat to caves.
 Those that gaze into the fire
 and enter its consumption rather than watching
 their world crumble.
 The relationship,
 the career,
 the identities,
 Ma is demanding.
 She wants and wants.
 A mirror of my own hunger.
 Forget the Devil, this is where I have sold my
 soul.
 To my ache and my desire.
 To the doorman, I am the same.
 To the grocery store clerk, I am the same.

To my neighbors, I am the same.

A women/girl with long hair and a large
 tattoo. Someone who likes to laugh, cook, watch
 funny films, make funny voices.

A martini now and then.

One olive, a little dirty.

"La, la, la, la, la" she says.

"Ha, ha, ha, ha, ha" she says

"Ma, Ma, Ma, Ma, Ma" she says

All this fed by the burning

the slithering of awakening

Inside this woman/girl are thought of daggers,

Hibiscus, incense, and intoxication.

Thoughts of ashes and cremation grounds.

Thoughts of wisdom of breasts, and blood and
 bone.

Inside this woman/girl is a thousand crows

a feline ferocity

a million rising suns

and a river of lunacy.

"La, la, la, la, la" she says.

"Ha, ha, ha ,ha ,ha" she says.

"Ma, Ma, Ma, Ma, Ma" she says.

Terrible Beauty

"To behold the beauty you must behold the
 terrifying." -Parvathi Nanda Nath

Ma slyly pulling threads

undoing me

it was her own fabric

the pattern she wove me into

is now the one that dissolves

I walk on each thread

like a tightrope

Today I suffered at another's suffering.

I can't quite get this

the pain inflicted on an innocent

and after all that

"this dog loves people"

How?! How?!

and I want to take everyone in my lap

and crush them with this sadness

Until they break open.

I laugh at this image

human pinatas

"whack!"

out spills the demons

"whack!"

out spills the moralities, the hurts, the pride

"whack, whack, whack!"

and we all dance

and sing mariachi!

softness permeates the loft this afternoon

curry wafting

cats sleeping

and the simpleness of it

all consoles me.

every night, I will come meet you Ma.

I will open my heart for your Dance

and drink of your nectar

Tear me open to the terrible

just to behold your beauty

self-preservation cast aside

an unnecessary veil to your touch

Sit with Shiva for eternity

Sit with Shiva for eternity

Sit with Shiva for eternity

Sit with Shiva for eternity.....



Feeding the Guardians

Flying on a mountain top

subtle breath

harnesses the wind

absorbed into light

—whose body is burning?||

Chinmamasta red

Orbit of life

Lightning Mother

Thundering thighs on the mountain

—whose body is burning?||

Vidyut power-

condensation of Kundalini;

Display of Ma

Sparkling teeth and sword

Wielding splendour

—whose body is burning?||

Pre-historic Shiva Lingams

Milk offering of clouds

Caressing the craggy ancient ones

Cupped by space

—whose body is burning?||

Yellow jewel

woven from subtle light

Honeyed hues

Skytrail of the Yogini's

Soaring to and fro

—whose body is burning?||

Water, wine, sacrifice

holy speech

midnight muttering

to establish the seat

Feeding the guardians

—whose body is burning?||

[**Nita Rubio** (Nisha Bhairavi) is a Priestess in the lineage of Woman Mysteries of the Ancient Future Sisterhood. It is this mystery school that gave Nita the tools and skills to walk visibly in the world as a teacher. It is also the core work of the lineage, the Tantric Dance of Feminine Power that allowed for Nita to be able to recognize the teachers of her continued education in the lineages of Kaula tantra, Sri Vidya and Kashmir Shaivism. She weaves into her verses a continuous stream of Feminine Divine.]

Sri Sankuka's interpretation of Rasa-Sutra

Geetika Kaw Kher

The Indian aesthetic thought is ruled by stalwarts like Bharata, Anandvardhana and Abhinavagupta. There has been considerable amount of research and critical examination in their works. The common thread binding all three of them is their thought provoking inputs on Rasa theory. Rasa--roughly translated: "as emotive aesthetics"--is one of the most important concepts in classical Indian aesthetics, having pervasive influence in theories of painting, sculpture, dance, poetry, and drama. . Rasa theory argues that the presentation of emotions is the proper object and domain of poetic discourse.

Bharata in *Natyashastra* his pioneering work on Indian dramatics mentions eight rasas and says Rasa is produced when '*Vibhava*', *Anubhava* and *Vyabhichari bhava* come together.

Vibhavanubhava-vyabhichari-samyogad Rasa nispattih

(*Rasa Sutra, Natyashastra*)

Vibhava: A medium through which an emotion arises in an actor e.g. A child riding a stick and enjoying it as if he were actually riding a horse.

Anubhava: All the physical changes arising due to the *vibhavas* e.g. changes in facial expression and body language

Vyabhichari bhava: Transient emotions eg. Weeping with joy.

However the whole discussion on Rasa and all the complex questions arising along with are incomplete without explaining the inputs from the other pre- Abhinavagupta commentators on Rasa Sutra from Kashmir. Any scholar or student who tries to venture into the depth of their contribution right at the onset faces a major crisis due to the lack of documentation and records. Hence when one started looking for Sri Sankuka's writing, one realized that none of the original stuff exists and only information about the scholar and his ideas can be gleaned through *Abhinavabharti* and writings of Mammata and Hemchandra. In the former text, the commentary on *Rasa Sutra* by Sankuka is explained in brief only to be refuted. Nonetheless this refutation cannot be taken as final and the scholar's work considered less important. As R B Patankar observes —...these three critics must have taken Sankuka's theory seriously: otherwise they would not have given it the space they have done in their writings; nor would have Bhatta Tauta thought it worth his while to attempt its detailed refutation...||²

One would like to plead for considering the theories of these commentators on Rasa Sutra not as important archaic steps leading towards the genius of Abhinavagupta but as independent theories having their own merits. In this short write-up, I am trying to look at Sri Sankuka's theory on Rasa and his interpretation of *Rasa Sutra* clearly from a logician's (nyayika's) point of view and point out its far-reaching philosophical and metaphysical aspects.

Born in Kashmir and trained in the Nyaya philosophy, Sri Sankuka used clear cut logic to explain his stand. He studied the *Rasa Sutra* not from the point of view of production of the aesthetic object on the stage, but

from the considerations of the matter in which aesthetic experience arises from the aesthetic object. He vehemently critiqued the theory of '*Art as imitation*' proposed by Bhattalollata, his older contemporary. His ground for such refutation was simply the fact that the basic mental state (*sthayi bhava*) cannot be imitated i.e. if an actor is playing the part of a victim of a tragedy; the actor himself does not undergo the pain and suffering of the character hence there is a sense of detachment. Here the actor is constantly trying to present a mental state and for all we know the basic mental state he himself is undergoing might be that of anxiety to do well on stage or anxiety about the success of the drama and what he could do with the money and the fame. Since the tragedy is neither the actor's nor the spectator's the feeling of enjoyment is possible. There is a sure 'proscenium barrier' which automatically puts the actors in a totally different plane...a place where for some time the audience can forget its existential dilemmas and enjoy someone else's tragedy or story....someone who is just in the realm of imagination.

Hence the point, which Sankuka tries to stress on, is that art cannot be an ordinary imitation but it is a kind of an indirect Inference. Hence the *sthayi bhava* of the character, which is inferred by the actor, is called Rasa. Thus Sri Sankuka interprets the *Rasa Sutra* to mean that the basic mental state inferred from *vibhavas* and *anubhavas* is Rasa.

AbhinavaBharti gives a detailed account of the theory of '*Chitaraturaga nyaya*', which is the most interesting contribution of Sankuka to the vast repertoire of aesthetic theories.

The arrangement of scenes etc. on the stage together with successful acting by the actor gives rise to the consciousness of the identity of the actor with the hero whom he impersonates. This consciousness is not of the nature of illusion nor of doubt. It cannot be said to be true or false. It is similar to the consciousness that one has at the sight of a life like picture of a particular horse and is called '*Analogy of a pictorial horse*' - '*Chitaraturaga nyaya*'. The perception relevant in art is different from the four known varieties of perception enumerated by the Sanskrit scholar's viz. veridical perception, false perception of resemblance and doubtful perception.

The most enigmatic and interesting question here is what kind of seeing is relevant for *citra-turaga pratiti*. To understand the concept, let us assume that one is looking at a painting. Actually what one is seeing is a framed piece of canvas with pigments spread over it but one often says that one can see a particular object which the picture reminds us of. Once that is established one identifies the other related objects in the painting.

That all these things are spatially and temporarily inter-related in certain ways is clear; but they are so inter-related in the picture-space and picture-time, which are not continuous with our space and time. To make it simpler one can take the example of the mirror space. The objects reflected in the mirror are the reflections of the objects placed in the room yet they exist in a different space altogether. Similar is the case with the picture.

Our relation with the objects in the picture-world appears to be peculiar. It appears that there is a limited one-way causal relation between these objects and us. To quote an example, suppose one is looking at a picture of a person. Whatever one does will have absolutely no effect on the person himself. Often as children one must have drawn beard and moustache on the pictures in the newspaper or magazines. While on one hand our drawing makes no difference to the person who is represented in the picture on the other hand neither can that picture admonish us or hit us for doing the mischief. But let us assume the picture is of a holy saint or a divinity that we revere then the image assumes an immense power. Then it gains the capacity to move the faithful onlooker though still it cannot move or come out of that picture frame. One feels that this wonderful argument of Sri Sankuka very beautifully and logically explains the essence of idol worship where the devotee is sure that the idol is just a medium. Hence devotees throughout the world have created

images of the deities and saints in whom they feel holy presence. The devotees are very much aware that the image is not the deity itself but just serves as a reminder of the all pervading one and as an object to concentrate ones devotion on. An image or an idol allows one to have a

Thus the beauty of his theory is not just limited to the Arts as it is understood in present day context. All the Indian aesthetes who have commented on the Rasa-Sutra of Bharata, essentially from Kashmir, have been great thinkers and philosophers in their own right. The fact that they could derive so much out of a simple appearing sutra and for generations comment on it talks of their excellent scholarship, power to articulate and condense the essence of the written word.

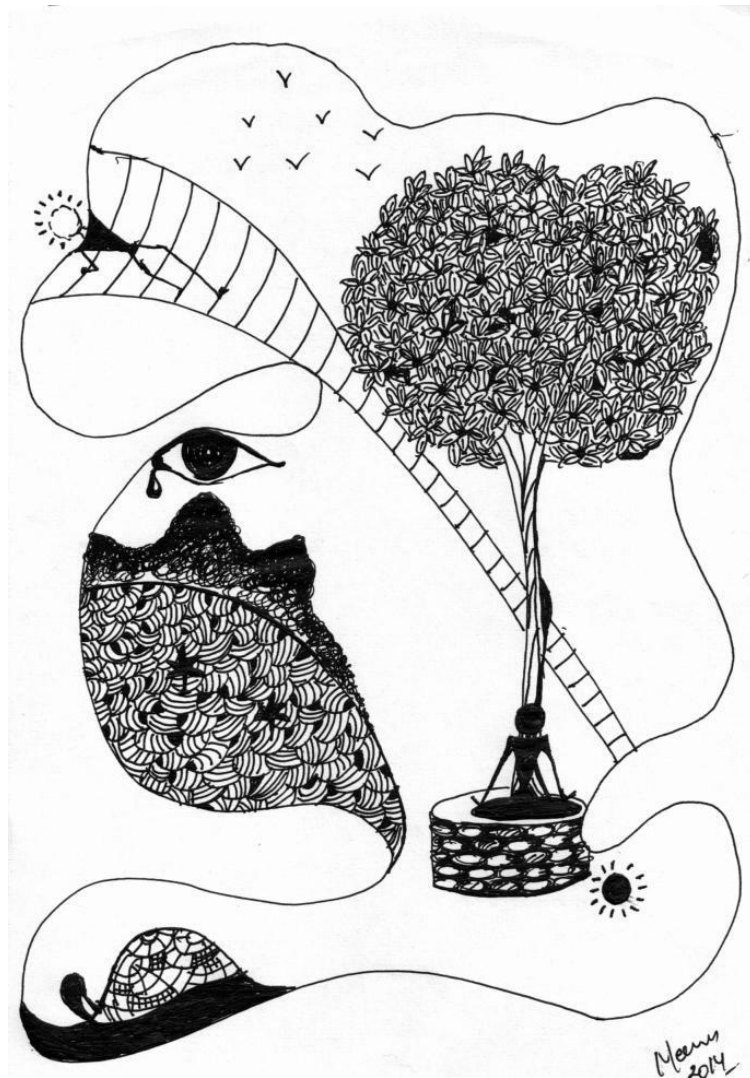
Notes:

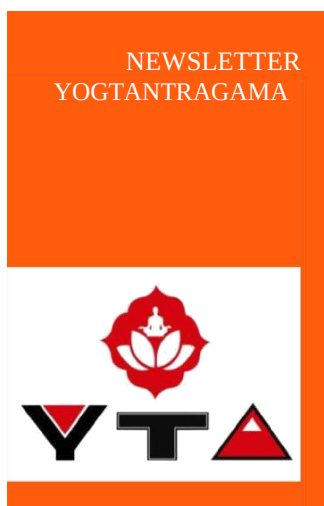
1. Kher, Kaw Geetika *‘A glimpse in Abhinavagupta’s ideas on aesthetics’* Sulekha.com
2. Patankar, R.B., *‘Sankuka-A Defense’* ed. By V.M Kulkarni
3. Kher, Kaw Geetika *‘Deeper meaning in idol worship’* Yogtantragama.com

References:

1. Mishra Hari Ram.1964. *‘The theory of Rasa in Sanskrit drama’*.
2. Raghavan, V. and Nagendra.1970. *‘An introduction to Indian Poetics’*
3. Toshkhani S.S.2003. *‘Kashmir’s Contribution to Indian Aesthetics-I’*, *Kashmir Sentinel*

one to one relationship with the deity and worship. Almighty is in form of mother, friend, lover, father and thus personalize their worship.





Published by: Rashneek Kher
901-902, Iris Tower, Faridabad, Haryana, 121010.
E-mail: swamiparanad@gmail.com.

Sketches: Rashneek Kher

Logo: Manik Chawla